

Lesson 1: Tkúpa Means Tule Place

Overview

Students learn the meaning of the place name Tkúpa and explore the relationships among the Indigenous Peoples of the area to this particular location along Ímatalam Wána (the Umatilla River). Students compare relationships among Indigenous Peoples and newcomers to this place before and during the encroachment of overland migrants.

Estimated Delivery Time

Two 30- to 50-minute sessions
dependent on how much
time is allocated for the
artifact rotation activity

Essential Questions (EQs)

What is the Umatilla tribal peoples' connection to Tkúpa and the surrounding area?
How did settlers traveling on the Oregon Trail understand their connection to the places they were traveling through? How did their encroachment on the Oregon landscape change indigenous relationships with places like Tkúpa?

Supporting Questions

How do languages hold meanings and worldviews?

Why is it valuable to learn other languages and understand other cultures' worldviews?

What kinds of intercultural interactions were common between overland migrants and Indigenous Peoples of this region?

Success Criteria

I am learning...

...the connections of tribal peoples to Tkúpa (Tule Place) and the surrounding area.

...how the overland migrants traveling through this region changed Indigenous Peoples' relationships with places like Tkúpa (Tule Place).

I will know I am successful when...

...I can articulate the importance and connections of tribal peoples to Tkúpa (Tule Place).

...I can identify and differentiate between artifacts that could have been used by migrants *and* Indigenous Peoples and artifacts likely used only by one of these cultural groups at Tkúpa (Echo, Oregon).

A Note on Language

The Confederated Tribes of the Umatilla Indian Reservation (CTUIR) is a name adopted by three distinct tribes – the Umatilla, Cayuse, & Walla Walla – following their adoption of a tribal constitution and bylaws in 1949. It is important to both recognize the distinctness of each of these tribes and the sovereignty of the CTUIR as a tribal nation when discussing Indigenous Peoples in the context of this unit.

Language within lessons will typically refer to individual or confederated tribes by name when applicable or refer to “Indigenous Peoples of the area” when discussing the dynamic interactions among tribal groups that transcend or predate federally recognized tribal nations. As you frame content for your students, please be mindful of specificity and the chronology of the creation of the CTUIR.

The term “overland migrants” has been intentionally used in this lesson and throughout the unit to foreground the most relevant characteristics of people traveling along the route we now refer to as the Oregon Trail. Since people were migrating west on ships long before this time, traveling the “overland route” is significant. All individuals regardless of race, religion, or destination in what became the western United States were migrants on this route. Using the term “migrants” in this context also challenges assumptions about concepts of indigeneity, citizenship, and race in a valuable way.

Ičiškiin Sínwit [Sahaptian Vocabulary]

[Link to interactive glossary.](#)

Lesson Vocabulary

[Link to interactive glossary.](#)

Background Information for Educators

Review background information prior to teaching the lesson.

- > Read [these selected sections from the Sahaptian Place Names Atlas](#) to learn from local indigenous leaders, knowledge keepers, and scholars about their homeland and culture.
- > Practice the pronunciation of the Sahaptian words included in this lesson using the [interactive glossary on the unit website](#). It may take some practice to feel comfortable saying words in a language that you may not be familiar with, but it's vital to incorporate the language into your teaching and model vulnerability and willingness to fail when learning new things.
- > Read [this Oregon Encyclopedia article](#) about the Oregon Trail.

Materials Needed

Gather the following materials:

- > The whole class Know Wonder Learn (KWL) graphic organizer from the Unit Introduction for ongoing assessment
- > “Tule Place Reflection Booklet” pages 4-7
- > Slide deck with embedded video(s). [[Website: For Educators > Slides](#)]
There is additional information in the “notes” section on the slideshows that may help you facilitate the lessons.
- > Objects from the Teaching Trunk labeled for Lesson 1
Please make sure to read the Health and Safety Note regarding the 3-D printed spur and gun hammer.
- > 10 sturdy paper plates or plastic trays for students to pass the objects on

Step-by-Step Instructions

Part One: Artifact Inquiry Activity (30-45 minutes)

1. Warm Up (5 minutes)

- Revisit the whole-class KWL chart where you left off from the last lesson with particular attention to what students are “wondering”
- Tell students that they will get to interact with some primary sources in today’s lesson that can help them answer some of their questions about what daily life might have been like at the place we call Echo, Oregon.

2. Model the “Observe – Interpret – Inquire” process (5 minutes)

- Have students turn to page 4 of their Reflection Booklets. Using the picture shown on slide 3, work through each step of the worksheet with students:
 - **Observe** [click slide] – describe the object/image
Use descriptive words to write what you notice about the image. What colors, shapes, and items do you see?
 - **Interpret** [click slide] – make an inference based on these observations
Write what and/or who you think the image is showing? Who might have taken this picture? Why do you think that?
Make sure to model the connections between observations and interpretations in explaining **why**.
 - **Inquire** [click slide] – ask questions based on what you think you know
What else do you want to know about this image? What questions do you have?
Emphasize questions of when, how, if, why, etc.

3. Talking Point

Now that we've practiced this way of thinking like a historian together, you're each going to get to look at some artifacts from the archaeological site near Echo. Some of these are modern reproductions and others are 3D printed replicas of real artifacts. ALL of them are breakable – please be careful and respectful of the objects so that other students can learn from them for a long time!

You will have around two minutes to look at each object and write your observations, interpretations, and inquiries. [Modify as appropriate]

4. Artifact Rotation (10 groups x 2-4 minutes)

- Establish the rotation rules/expectations so that students know who is passing their items and where they are passing their items when the time is up.
- Distribute the objects to each student group, set a two-minute (or more) timer, and begin the rotations.
- Give a 10-second warning before each rotation time is up.
- Have students pass items every two minutes until each group has had the chance to look at all the replicas.

5. Debrief (5 minutes)

- Have students share some of the questions they have about these artifacts with their classmates. You can ask guiding questions if needed:
 - *Whose belongings do you think these were? Why?*
 - *Which people were interacting with these items? Where (outside, inside, what part of the house, etc.)? Why do you think that?*

NOTE: Depending on how long you want to give your students for the artifact rotations, you may want to separate this lesson into two delivery sessions. If you decide to complete this lesson in two separate sessions, you will want to revisit the KWL Graphic Organizer as a class as part of your debrief above **AND again** as a reminder of where you left off before resuming Part Two below.

Part Two: Context and Connections

6. Show and discuss the embedded videos

- Show the embedded video on slide 5 about Tkúpa (tule place) and what life would have been like there.
 - After the video, have students talk **briefly** to their neighbors about how their understanding of the items may have changed with this new information. Have them write down new ideas on their Observe-Interpret-Inquire booklet pages.
- Show the embedded video on slide 7 describing “The Lower Crossing” of the Umatilla River.
 - After the video, have students talk **briefly** to their neighbors about how their understanding of the items may have changed with this new information. Have them write down additional ideas on their Observe-Interpret-Inquire worksheet pages.

NOTE: Ideally, students should recognize that many of the items were likely used by both Indigenous Peoples *and* overland migrants with several exceptions based on cultural differences and transportation needs. For example, Indigenous Peoples did not use spurs or have need of oxen (nor ox shoes).

Part Three: Lesson Closure/Reflection

7. Revisit the KWL graphic organizer both as a class and pages 1-3 in their Reflection Booklets; add any **new** things that students have “learned” or are “wondering” about Tkúpa (Tule Place). **TIP:** Use a different colored marker/pen to help make students’ learning visible over time!
8. Have students record the class ideas on the “Wonder” (pg. 2) and “Learn” (pg. 3) pages of their Reflection Booklet. Students can also copy the class-generated ideas later during a writing period if writing speed is a concern.

Assessment

This lesson can be assessed using the following:

- > Completed Observe-Interpret-Inquire worksheets on pages 4-7 of their Reflection Booklet
- > Individual KWL graphic organizer in the Reflection Booklet pages 1-3

Support for All Students

Student supports include:

- > A scaffolded version of the booklet is available for students who would benefit from more structured guidance. This version is designated by the river icon on the cover page. [[Website: For Educators > Printables](#)]
- > You can turn on closed captions for any of the videos to help students follow along. Transcripts are also available.
- > If students do not possess fine motor skills to safely pass the artifact replicas through the classroom, please consider having the items stay at stations with students moving between stations OR facilitate the movement of replicas between groups yourself to reduce the chance of items breaking while moving through the classroom.

Extensions

Student extensions include:

- > Consider including the vocabulary from this lesson in other spelling or language practice by using the words in your regular spelling lessons or by having students make flashcards to practice acquiring new vocabulary.
- > The freshwater mussel shells included among the hands-on items for this lesson provide an excellent opportunity for biology and/or food sovereignty conversations with your students. Consider introducing students to the [CTUIR Freshwater Mussel Research and Restoration Project \(FWMRRP\)](#) – the first of its kind in the Columbia Basin. Students can explore the information provided on their own as a research project or you might prepare an in-class overview as a cue set for a species identification activity. The mussels included in this Teaching Trunk include all three of the different species found within the FWMRRP area and the [Quick Reference Guide](#) provides students with all the information they will need to identify shells from the different species.
- > Other intercultural extensions related to this timeframe include the [Chinese Diaspora Traveling Trunk](#) and the [Oregon's Black Pioneers Traveling Trunk](#) available through the [Oregon Historical Society's education program](#).

Oregon Grade 4 Social Science Standards

- 4.C.IR.3** Examine how identity shapes perspectives about a local or state issue.
- 4.G.GR.2** On political and physical maps of North America, locate significant sites in the United States, Mexico, Canada, Oregon, Nevada, Alaska, Hawai`i, Washington, Idaho, and California.
- 4.G.MM.4** Compare and contrast varying patterns of exploration and settlement in the Pacific Northwest over time, considering how physical features and the availability of natural resources affected exploration and settlement patterns, including the development of major urban/suburban areas, industries, or trade.
- 4.G.MM.5** Explain how the contributions of the Indigenous Tribes of Oregon and various historical and contemporary immigrant groups create the diverse culture of present-day Oregon.
- 4.G.HI.6** Assess how physical geography and changing environmental factors affect land use and shape the cultural characteristics of a society.
- 4.E.ST.10** Explain how trade leads to increasing economic interdependence.
- 4.H.CH.1** Identify and examine the Indigenous sovereign people of Oregon prior to and during waves of exploration and settlement from Europe and the United States.
- 4.H.CH.2** Investigate the role of “Manifest Destiny” and racial prejudice in shaping Oregon’s transition from “Oregon Country” to statehood. Include the legal, political, and cultural factors causing marginalization and attempts to promote inclusivity.
- 4.H.CC.3** Identify examples of Indigenous resistance to the expansion of non-Indigenous settlers into Oregon lands in the causes and results of the battles and wars in Oregon Territory and 19th century Oregon.
- 4.H.CE.5** Use multiple sources to explore the Oregon Trail’s significance in shaping Oregon history, examining its role in westward expansion, cultural interactions, and settlement patterns.
- 4.H.CP.6** Identify the history, religion, languages, and cultural practices of the Indigenous Tribes of Oregon and examples of resistance and resilience to immigration and settlement by the United States.

Oregon Grade 4 English Language Arts Standards (2026)

- 4.RL.9** Compare/contrast themes, topics and patterns of events in stories, myths, and traditional literature from different cultures.
- 4.RI.7** Interpret information presented visually, orally, or quantitatively in print and non-print formats and explain how the information contributes to an understanding of the text in which it appears.
- 4.W.2e** Use precise language and domain-specific vocabulary to inform about or explain the topic.
- 4.L.3a** Choose words and phrases to convey ideas precisely.
- 4.SL.1** Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions with diverse partners on grade 4 topics and texts, building on others' ideas and expressing personal ideas clearly.
 - 4.SL.1a** Come to discussions prepared, having read or studied required material; explicitly draw on that preparation and other information known about the topic to explore ideas under discussion.
 - 4.SL.1b** Follow agreed-upon rules for discussions and carry out assigned roles.
 - 4.SL.1d** Review the key ideas expressed and explain personal ideas and understanding in light of the discussion.